

Outlook India — "10 Years of Kapoor & Sons: The Uneasy, Ongoing Negotiation of Being a Family" (2026)

What this piece actually is

This is a retrospective critical essay written on the film's 10th anniversary. The author has a decade of distance and uses it well — this isn't a review, it's an analysis of *why the film holds up* and *what it was really doing* that wasn't fully appreciated in 2016. The central argument is that K&S was never really about queerness or even romance — it was always about **the family as a site of quiet, ongoing violence**.

1. The Film's Real Subject — Dysfunctionality as the Plot

The essay opens by noting what most popular reviews got wrong in 2016: they treated the family drama as the backdrop and Rahul's queerness as the "twist." The Outlook piece reverses this entirely.

The dysfunctionality *is* the film. The grandfather's imminent death is not a plot device to bring characters together — it is a **deadline that forces a family to attempt, one last time, the performance they have always been doing: pretending to be a happy family for a photograph**. The film is literally about whether this family can take *one photograph together*. Everything else — the affairs, the lies, the favoritism, the money — is what's been hiding underneath that photograph for decades.

Across *Ek Main Aur Ekk Tu*, *Kapoor & Sons* and *Gehraiyaan*, Batra and co-writer Ayesha Devitre Dhillon repeatedly return to familiar relational templates, only to recontextualise them. This is the Outlook piece's way of saying K&S doesn't just tell a family story — it systematically dismantles every comforting template Indian audiences bring to a family film and shows what's actually inside. [Sacnilk](#)

2. Harsh — A Masculinity Study in Failure

Harsh (Rajat Kapoor) is one of the most important characters in the film for your course, and he's the one most underanalysed because he's not the protagonist. The Outlook piece corrects this.

Harsh is the **archetypal failed patriarch**. He has internalised every expectation of what an Indian man and father should be — provider, authority figure, head of household — and has quietly been failing at all of them for years. He cannot financially support his family. His wife has more practical sense than he does. He has an ongoing affair with a colleague named Anu, which is **at least partly an escape from the humiliation of feeling inadequate at home**.

What makes Harsh interesting rather than simply villainous is the film's refusal to make him a monster. He is a **frustrated middle-aged man who is always at odds with himself** — someone who wanted more from life and got less, and turned that resentment inward and outward in equal measure. His affair is not coded as pure desire — it's coded as the one place in his life where he feels like the version of himself he wanted to be.

The masculinity point for your parallels essay: contrast Harsh with Baldev Singh in *DDLJ*. Both are patriarchs. Both have authority over their families. But **Baldev Singh's patriarchy is secure** — he is the unchallenged head of household, his authority is never questioned by circumstances, only by his daughter's love for the wrong man. Harsh's patriarchy is *hollow* — he performs authority while his wife runs the household finances, while his sons barely respect him, while he sneaks around behind

everyone's backs. K&S shows patriarchy not as the stable oppressive structure DDLJ presents, but as a *performance of competence that no one believes anymore*.

3. Sunita — The Film's Most Complex Character

This is where the Outlook piece does its best work, and it directly relates to your course's interest in how masculinity and patriarchy function *through* women as much as on them.

Sunita (Ratna Pathak Shah) is a woman who wanted a shop. This detail — mentioned almost in passing in the film — is the essay's anchor for understanding her character. She had an entrepreneurial ambition. She wanted to run a business. That ambition was absorbed into the family, sublimated, denied — and what's left is a woman who *channels all of that energy into managing her sons instead*.

Love, here, is unevenly distributed not because one child deserves it more, but because one is easier to love. Sunita's favoritism toward Rahul is not simply maternal preference — it is a *displacement of ambition*. Rahul is the successful writer. He achieved what she couldn't. She lives through him. Her love for him is real, but it is also a kind of ownership — she loves the version of him that validates her own unlived life. [Sacnilk](#)

This makes the confrontation scene, when she discovers Rahul's relationship with a man, devastating on multiple levels. *She doesn't just lose the son she thought she knew — she loses the projection of herself she had invested in him*. Her breakdown is not only homophobia. It is the collapse of a fantasy she had been sustaining for decades. She accuses him of lying and wonders what she's done to deserve a son like him. The cruelty of that line comes from the fact that she genuinely does not understand — she has been too busy watching the performance to see the person. [siasat](#)

The DDLJ parallel here is precise and damning. Simran's mother in DDLJ also has a suppressed inner life — she makes that famous speech about sacrificing her education, her desires, her selfhood. But her role in the narrative is ultimately to *facilitate the patriarchal resolution*: she hands Simran jewels and tells her to run. She enables the system even as she critiques it. Sunita in K&S is far messier — she is the system's enforcer who doesn't even know she's enforcing it. She genuinely believes her favoritism is love.

4. The Favoritism Structure — How Families Distribute Love Unevenly

The Outlook essay treats this as the film's moral core. Rahul is the preferred one, the golden child because he is successful and more crucially, *he is compliant with the family's expectations*. Like most such children, he grows up into an adult who learns to lie and hide himself better in front of his family than the other sibling. Arjun's resentment stems from years of being measured against an impossible standard and blatant betrayal — *for the longest time Arjun believes Rahul stole his first novel's idea, only for Sunita to confess later that she gave his manuscript to Rahul because she never took Arjun's ambitions seriously*. [Sacnilk](#)

Break this down for your exam — there are two simultaneous injustices happening:

Arjun's injustice is visible and felt — he was deprived, overlooked, his work literally taken and given to his brother. His resentment makes sense and is legible. But the essay points out that Arjun's resentment is directed at *Rahul* rather than at the parents who created the structure. The brothers

fight each other rather than the system that pitted them against each other. This is exactly how unjust family structures sustain themselves.

Rahul's injustice is invisible even to him — he was the *recipient* of favoritism, but what that favoritism required was a lifetime of performed compliance. He had to be the perfect son to keep the love. The cost of being loved in this family was never being *known*. His closet and his golden-child status are the same structure.

5. The Film's Relationship to Normal Bollywood — Why It's Structurally Radical

The Outlook essay makes a point about form that's worth having for cinematography and director's POV questions. Normal Bollywood family films resolve dysfunction through the family photograph — the literal restoration of the happy image. Think of every family reunion film where the climax is everyone coming together, tears, forgiveness, music swells.

K&S gets to the photograph — but only *after* Harsh dies. The family takes the photo with a *cutout of the father* in his place. This is the film's darkest joke and its sharpest structural statement: the happy family photograph that drives the entire plot is ultimately *literally incomplete*. The patriarch who demanded the image of unity is absent from it. The family achieves the image of togetherness only when the person who most demanded it is gone. The image of the family was always more important to the family than the reality of it.

Compare this to DDLJ's final image — Simran running toward Raj on the train platform, the father's outstretched arm releasing her. That is a resolved image. A closed gesture. K&S gives you a photograph with a cardboard cutout. That's the difference between a film that *resolves* patriarchy sentimentally and one that *exposes* what patriarchy actually costs.

One-Line Exam Version

The Outlook piece argues: **K&S is a film about how Indian families distribute love unequally and call it devotion — Harsh performs a masculinity he can't sustain, Sunita channels suppressed ambition into suffocating favoritism, and the family photograph that drives the entire plot is only taken once the patriarch who demanded it is dead.**

ScoopWhoop — "Masculinity, Sexuality and Kapoor & Sons" (2016)

What the article is

Written right after the film's release in March 2016, this is a piece of popular film journalism — not academic, but sharp. The author is writing from inside the cultural moment, reacting to the film's immediate impact. That's its value: it captures what felt *new* about K&S to a 2016 audience that had grown up on the masculinity templates of DDLJ and its successors.

1. The Line That Anchors Everything

The article opens with the scene that matters most for your masculinity discussion — Rahul confronting his mother after she discovers his laptop photographs. The line he delivers:

"Are you angry at my lies, or are you sad about my truth?"

The moment is sublime, raw, and makes you gasp. [YouTube](#)

Hold this line for your exam because it works on every level your course cares about. It isn't just about queerness — it's about **the entire structure of the Kapoor family**. Every character in this film is living a lie that their family has preferred over their truth. Harsh is lying about Anu. Sunita is lying about the state of her marriage. Arjun is lying about not caring that he was never taken seriously. The film's thesis is in that line: Indian families, as K&S presents them, are built on a mutual agreement to prefer comfortable lies over painful truths. Rahul just happens to be the one who gets caught first.

2. What the Article Does for Masculinity — Rahul vs. The Template

The article's core contribution is establishing exactly what kind of masculinity Rahul represents *against the Bollywood baseline*. This matters for your DDLJ parallel.

Fawad Khan's Rahul Kapoor is unlike any mainstream gay character you've met. He's reliable, mature, and levelheaded. His family turns to him in times of crisis to sort things out. He doesn't talk about fashion. He's reserved. He never shies from letting anyone know he's in a committed relationship with someone he's very much in love with. His masculinity is never questioned. He's just a man who is in love with another man. [YouTube](#)

Now strip away the queerness angle entirely and read that description again — reliable, mature, levelheaded, the one the family turns to in crisis, reserved, committed. That is a description of **emotional masculinity**. The kind of man who holds things together, who absorbs the family's dysfunction, who is present when needed. It's worth asking: who does this sound like in DDLJ?

It sounds like **Raj**. Not the loud flirtatious Raj of the first half — but the Raj of the Punjab sequences, who fasts on Karva Chauth, sits with the grandmother, helps in the kitchen, patiently endures Baldev Singh's hostility. Both Raj and Rahul perform a *feminised* emotional labour that traditional Indian masculinity would reject — and both films position this as the *superior* form of masculinity.

The critical difference: Raj's emotional availability is ultimately in service of *winning* the patriarchal structure (he earns Simran through the father). Rahul's emotional availability earns him nothing — his family still can't see him. The emotional labour that made Raj a hero makes Rahul invisible.

3. Harsh as the Opposite of Raj — The Patriarchy Comparison

This is where the ScoopWhoop article, read alongside the Outlook piece, becomes most useful for your course.

The article describes what Bollywood has traditionally done with masculinity — big, loud, dominant, sexually aggressive. Harsh is interesting because he is none of these things on the surface, and yet he perpetuates the same structures. He is a **quietly failing patriarch** — a man who performs domestic authority without the competence to back it up.

Compare this directly to Baldev Singh in DDLJ. Both are fathers. Both have failing domestic situations. But:

Baldev Singh's patriarchy is externally secure. His authority within the family is total and unquestioned. His failure is *ideological* — he clings to tradition at the cost of his daughter's happiness. But nobody in the household doubts that he is in charge. His masculinity is never undermined by circumstance.

Harsh's patriarchy is internally hollow. His wife has more practical authority than he does. He has a secret affair that isn't about passion so much as escape from inadequacy. His sons don't respect him — Arjun resents him, Rahul barely knows him despite being his confidant. His masculinity is perpetually undermined by the gap between what he is supposed to be and what he actually is.

This is K&S's most damning statement about the 21 years between these two films: **the Indian patriarch didn't become more equal or more honest between 1995 and 2016 — he just became more obviously a performance.** Baldev Singh at least believed in his own authority. Harsh knows somewhere that his is hollow, and the affair is his way of not dealing with that knowledge.

4. The Bollywood Lineage — Why K&S Felt Radical in 2016

Bollywood's stereotypical gay man likes pink. He's a predator who simply can't keep it in his pants. He essentially acts like a stereotypical woman. He's a zoo animal offered for your consumption. A comedic relief. [YouTube](#)

Keep this for the broader masculinity argument, not just the queer angle. What this list describes is Bollywood's anxiety about any masculinity that doesn't conform — queer men are stereotyped as feminine because *femininity* is the thing Bollywood masculinity is defined *against*. The ideal man in DDLJ and most of its successors is defined partly by what he is not: not weak, not feminine, not uncontrolled.

K&S breaks this in two ways simultaneously. It presents a queer man who is more stereotypically "masculine" (reliable, competent, financially independent, emotionally restrained) than the heterosexual men around him. And it presents Harsh — the heterosexual patriarch — as emotionally incompetent, financially failing, and secretly running away from his own life. The film completely inverts the axis. **Queerness doesn't make Rahul less of a man. Heterosexuality doesn't make Harsh more of one.**

5. The Article's Honest Limitation — and Why It Matters

The central romantic plot still belongs to a woman and a man, and the only scene between the two gay characters who are in a relationship is completely sanitised — a birthday celebration, where cake gets cut and fed. The two romantic kisses featured onscreen are heteronormative. The movie ensures it doesn't push too many buttons, and that's disappointing. [YouTube](#)

This limitation is actually your clearest evidence of **what K&S can and cannot do** within the mainstream Bollywood system. It can **humanise queerness. It cannot fully represent it.** It can critique patriarchy. It cannot dismantle it — Harsh dies, but the family still gathers under the grandfather's wish for a unified image. The structure reasserts itself even at the end.

This is the crucial difference from *Animal*, where the structure doesn't even pretend to be questioned. *K&S* at least shows you the cracks. **DDLJ plastered over the cracks with charm.** *Animal* demolished the wall and called it freedom.

One-Line Exam Version

The ScoopWhoop piece argues: ***K&S* is radical because it positions emotional reliability as masculinity's highest form — then shows that this form earns a man nothing in the Indian family, while exposing the heterosexual patriarch as the film's actual failure.**

The DDLJ–K&S Masculinity Comparison — Pulled Together

Since this is what your course most needs, here's the parallel in clean form you can use in any essay or exam:

	DDLJ (Raj)	K&S (Rahul)	K&S (Harsh)
Masculinity type	Romantic patriarch-in-waiting	Emotional caretaker	Hollow patriarch
Relationship to family	Earns entry through compliance	Born into it, hides within it	Heads it, undermines it
Emotional labour	Weaponised to win Simran	Given freely, goes unseen	Absent, outsourced to wife
Outcome	Rewarded — gets the girl	Exposed — loses the performance	Punished — dies
What the film says	Comply with patriarchy beautifully and it will embrace you	Comply with patriarchy perfectly and it will never see you	Run the patriarchy badly and it will destroy you

That table is the argument across both films on masculinity. *DDLJ* says the right kind of man can work within the system. *K&S* says the system breaks every kind of man — the one who performs it poorly dies, and the one who performs it most perfectly was never really there.

The Realism Toolkit — Close Reading Details for *K&S*

1. The House as Financial Crisis

This is a *mise-en-scène* argument and it's sharp. The Kapoor house in Coonoor is not a Bollywood family home. It is cramped, slightly shabby, lived-in, cluttered. The wallpaper is peeling in places. The kitchen is functional not beautiful. There is no sprawling haveli, no marble floors, no visual grammar of upper-middle-class aspiration that Bollywood uses as default setting for family dramas.

This is a deliberate directorial choice by Batra and DP Anil Mehta. The house *is* the financial crisis before anyone says a word about it. Harsh's inadequacy as a provider is spatially encoded — you feel it in the rooms before you hear it in the arguments. When the family bickers about money, the setting has already confirmed it. The audience isn't surprised because the house told them first.

Compare this directly to DDLJ. Baldev Singh runs a *corner shop* — technically also a modest financial situation — but Chopra never lets the *mise-en-scène* feel modest. The London home is warm and lit beautifully. The Punjab home is golden, lush, full of folk music and color. The financial reality of an immigrant shopkeeper never registers visually because the film actively works against it aesthetically.

K&S does the opposite — it lets the walls do the talking. This is part of what makes it tend toward realism. The setting doesn't beautify the family's situation; it confirms it.

Academic language to use: *mise-en-scène* as ideological statement. The house as a *synecdoche* for the family's actual condition — what you see on the walls is what the family has been hiding about itself.

2. The Love Triangle Trope — and How K&S Subverts It

Bollywood love triangles follow a fixed grammar: two men compete for a woman, one wins, one loses nobly or turns villain. The woman is the prize; her interiority is secondary to the competition.

K&S sets up what looks like exactly this — Tia (Alia Bhatt) kisses Rahul, then develops feelings for Arjun. Two brothers, one girl. Classic triangle geometry.

But the film completely deflates it. First, **Rahul is gay** — so his side of the triangle was never real, which retroactively makes the triangle a *misunderstanding* rather than a competition. Second, and more importantly, Tia is not the film's emotional centre. The triangle is a *red herring* — it exists to bring the brothers into proximity and conflict, not to resolve which man "gets" the woman. Tia's feelings for Arjun are a subplot, not the destination.

What this does structurally: it uses the love triangle trope to comment on the love triangle trope. The audience arrives expecting the familiar grammar and the film keeps refusing to deliver it. The real drama is not between two brothers competing for a woman — **it is between two brothers competing for their *parents'* love**. The actual love triangle in K&S is **Rahul, Arjun, and Sunita's approval**. That is the triangle that generates all the real heat.

This is directly relevant to your masculinity discussion. In DDLJ the love triangle (Raj vs Kuljeet) is entirely about two men and their competing masculinities — Simran is the prize that measures which man is more authentically Indian. K&S refuses that structure. The woman in the triangle turns out to be incidental; the real competition was always about the family.

3. Dadu — Not a Manchild, Actually the Film's Moral Compass

This is a wonderful observation and one that most analyses miss entirely. Rishi Kapoor's Amarjeet (Dadu) is played in heavy prosthetics as a 90-year-old man, and the temptation with such a character in Bollywood is to make him either a weeping sentimental figure or a comedic old fool.

Batra does neither. Dadu is the only character in the film who is completely honest. He knows his **family is dysfunctional — he's lived through all of it**. He doesn't pretend otherwise. The famous scene

where he smokes weed with the grandchildren is not played for cheap laughs — it's the one moment in the film where the generational wall comes down and real conversation becomes possible. He creates the space for honesty that the middle generation (Harsh and Sunita) have completely failed to create.

His one wish — the family photograph — is not naïve sentimentality. He knows what the family is. He wants the image anyway. There's a maturity to that desire: he isn't asking for the dysfunction to be resolved, he's asking for the family to choose each other despite it. That's a more sophisticated emotional request than anything Harsh or Sunita manage in the entire film.

He is also the only male figure in the film whose masculinity is entirely unperformed. He's 90 years old — he has nothing left to prove. He doesn't need to be the provider, the patriarch, the authority figure. And paradoxically he is the most whole person in the film because of it. The film uses him to show what masculinity looks like when it has nothing to defend — it looks like warmth, honesty, and the willingness to sit with your grandchildren and smoke up.

Contrast this with Harsh, who is performing patriarch while failing at it, and Raj in DDLJ, who is performing the ideal Indian man for an audience of one (Baldev Singh). Dadu performs nothing. He just is. That's the film's quiet argument about what age and honesty do to masculinity — they strip the performance away and what's left is either real or nothing.

4. The Film's Tendency Toward Realism — What That Actually Means

This is worth unpacking as a concept because "realism" in cinema is a formal choice, not just a vibe. K&S earns the label through several specific decisions:

No resolution of the central problems. Harsh's affair isn't forgiven and healed — he dies. Sunita's favouritism isn't resolved — the film just ends with her asking after Rahul's "dost." The financial crisis isn't fixed. The brothers' relationship is repaired but only partially. Real families don't get clean resolutions; K&S respects this.

The plumber scene. This was mentioned in the Batra interview material — it's the scene where a plumber tries to fix the kitchen sink while the entire family argues loudly around him. It became the film's most quoted moment of dark comedy precisely because it's so recognisably real. Dysfunction doesn't pause for privacy. Life keeps going while families fall apart.

The multi-angle shooting method. As Batra himself described — covering every scene from multiple angles gave the film a documentary-like spontaneity. Reactions look unguarded because they were captured in multiple takes from different positions, and the best unrehearsed moments were kept. The film *looks* real because it was shot in a way that caught reality.

The Coonoor setting. Not Mumbai, not London, not a fantasised Punjab. A quiet, misty, slightly faded hill station that feels like a real place where real people have lived for a long time. The setting has no cinematic glamour. It just sits there, slightly damp, slightly past its prime — exactly like the family.

Contrast with DDLJ's anti-realism: DDLJ is formally anti-realist — the Swiss Alps, the golden mustard fields, the perfect London home, the songs, the impeccable costumes. It is cinema as fantasy. K&S is cinema as recognition. Where DDLJ asks you to aspire, K&S asks you to identify.

How All These Elements Work Together

The house, the subverted love triangle, Dadu's honesty, and the realist formal choices are not separate details — they are all doing the same thing. They are all **stripping away the aesthetics that Indian family cinema uses to make patriarchy and dysfunction feel acceptable or beautiful.**

DDLJ gives you golden fields and a beautiful romance to make you okay with Simran having no agency. K&S gives you peeling wallpaper and an unresolved ending to make sure you cannot aestheticise the Kapoor family's failures. The realism is political. It refuses you the comfort of beauty.

That's the deepest parallel between the two films for your course: they are making opposite formal choices that produce opposite ideological effects. One says the Indian family is worth protecting and its structures are beautiful. The other says the Indian family is worth examining honestly, and honesty reveals it as a site of quiet damage.